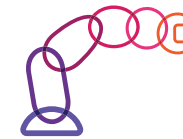


Git & GitHub Workshop

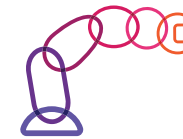
For Windows Users

19 & 21 May 2026



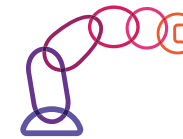
The Workshop

- The objectives of this workshop are:
 - To understand what Git is, why it was developed and the basic principles of how it works.
 - To be able to use Git & GitHub when working on your own.
 - To be understand how to work in a small team.
 - To be able to contribute to an Open Source project using GitHub.
 - To understand what GitHub Enterprise is and how you can use it at work.
- The workshop consists of two parts.
 - Each part lasts 2 hours 30 minutes with a 10 minute comfort break roughly halfway.
 - The general approach is that there will be 5 to 10 minutes of presentation followed by practical exercises.
 - The first few exercises will use a GitHub codespace so we understand the basic principles. Towards the end of the first session, we will set up our Windows PCs so that we can use Git and GitHub and then use our PCs from then on.



What is Git?

- Git is a Version Control System (VCS)
- A VCS allows you to store different versions of files. This is how a person who does not have a version control system might work on a program.
 - 1) Create the program file and call it “project.py”
 - 2) Spend a few hours coding and you have your first version so you call it “project-draft.py”
 - 3) You add a new feature and save it in “project-draft-2.py”
 - 4) You tidy it up and send it off for review calling it “project-review.py”
 - 5) You get lots of useful feedback and implement it in “project-post-review.py”
 - 6) You send it for review again. Only a few changes this time implemented in “project-final.py”
- This is a manual way of creating revisions. Let’s look at the same example but using a VCS.

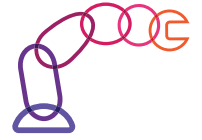


What is Git? - 2

- This is the equivalent of the previous example using a VCS.
 - 1) You create the project in the VCS and add the file called “project.py”.
 - 2) Add some code to the file and test it. Once it works, you add the new revision of “project.py” to the VCS with a message “Implemented first feature. Working”
 - 3) Add some more code for the second feature and add the new revision of “project.py” to the VCS with a message “Implemented second feature. Working”
 - 4) You check your work, write the documentation and add the new revision of “project.py” to the VCS with a message “Added documentation. Ready for review”.
 - 5) After the review, you fix up the issues and add the new revision of “project.py” to the VCS with a message “Fixed review comments. Ready for second review”.
 - 6) The review comes back with a couple of typos to fix. Add the new revision of “project.py” to the VCS with a message “Fixed more review comments. Ready for deployment”.

Using a VCS, the file name does not change. Each revision has its own message to explain the changes made between the labelled revision and the previous one.

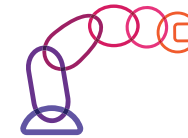
What is Git? - 3



- So what about a project that has multiple files? Here is an example:

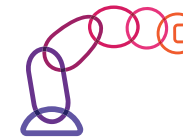
Version 1 "Wrote requirements. Added main.cpp"	my-project/v1/docs/requirements.md /src/main.cpp
Revision 2 "Added camera interface."	my-project/v2/docs/requirements.md /include/camera.h /src/main.cpp /camera.cpp
Revision 3 "Added timer to automatically take photos at timed intervals. Internal defaults to 1 photo per second."	my-project/v3/docs/requirements.md /tests.md /include/camera.h /timer.h /src/main.cpp /camera.cpp /timer.cpp

- As you can see, the messages that go with each revision are much easier to understand than a file name.
- Over the years, there have been many different VCSs, but currently, Git is the most popular.



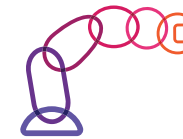
History of Git Development

- Back in 2005, Linus Torvalds was leading the development of the Linux kernel and he needed a replacement for the BitKeeper VCS they had been using. Git was developed with four guiding principles in mind:
 - Patching should take no more than three seconds.
 - Take the Concurrent Versions System (CVS) as an example of what not to do; if in doubt, make the exact opposite decision.
 - Support a distributed, BitKeeper-like workflow.
 - Include very strong safeguards against corruption, either accidental or malicious.
- It was developed very rapidly, starting on the 3 April 2005 with it being good enough to manage the kernel 2.6.12 release on 16th June 2005.
- Torvalds quipped about the name git (which is British English slang for an unpleasant or silly person): "I'm an egotistical bastard, and I name all my projects after myself. First 'Linux', now 'git'."
- The trademark "Git" is registered by the Software Freedom Conservancy.



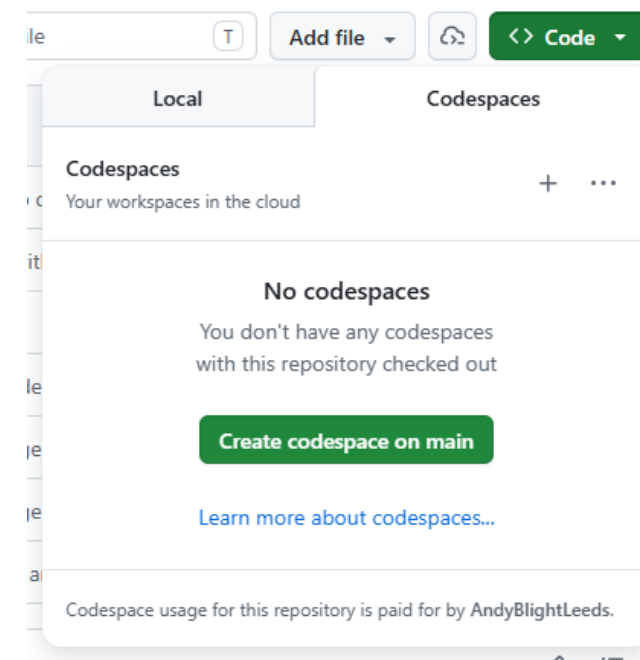
How Git Works

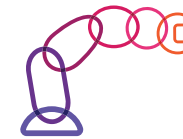
- Git is very fast and efficient and was built rapidly. How does it work?
 - Built on two existing Unix utilities, **diff** and **patch**.
 - Using **diff** and **patch**, you can compare two versions of the same file and generate a patch file. Then you can apply the patch file to the older version to create the newer version, or you can take the new version, reverse the patch file contents and then apply that to get the previous version.
 - This is where the phrase “patching a program” comes.
 - This is also the basic principle that Git is built upon.
 - The Git command line interface (CLI) add methods to track each version and methods to create, merge and delete branches (more on those later).



Diff and Patch Exercise

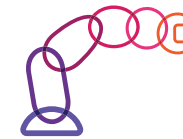
- **Diff** and **Patch** exercise. NOTE: This exercise only works on Linux, as **diff** and **patch** are not easy to install on Windows. So, we are going to use a GitHub Codespace for this exercise.
 - 1) In your browser, login in to GitHub.
 - 2) The copy and paste this URL into your browser:
<https://github.com/AndyBlightLeeds/git-github-practicals>
 - 3) Click on the green “Code” button and then the “Codespaces” tab and you should see this.
 - 4) The click on the “Create codespace on main” button.
 - 5) After a while, you should see the browser window open something that looks exactly like VSCode. You are now running an Ubuntu container in the cloud.
Codespaces allow you to edit and test your code only using browser.





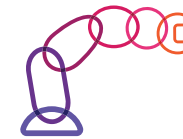
Diff and Patch Exercise - 2

- Now lets look at the **diff** and **patch** example.
 - 1) Open the “diff-patch-demo” folder.
 - 2) Open the file “README.md” and follow the instructions. Execute the command line instructions in the Terminal window at the bottom of the editor. Just copy and past the instructions on by one and see what happens. If all goes well, you should see the same results as those shown in the “README.md” file.
- This exercise has shown you how Git uses **diff** and **patch** to track the changes between each revision. It also showed how **git status** can be used to show you the changes that have been made to the repo.
- For the next few exercises, you are going to have to use the
- In the next exercise, you are going to create your first repo in GitHub and open it in a Codespace.



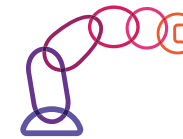
Using Git on your own - Exercise

- As our first step, I am going to talk you through creating your first GitHub repo and open it in a Codespace. Follow along with me.
 - 1) Login to your GitHub.
 - 2) Create a new repository (repo).
 - 3) Available options are:
 - 1) Select public if you want others to see it, private otherwise.
 - 2) Templates (ignore as mainly for businesses), select No.
 - 3) README** (useful so add it) – Enable.
 - 4) .gitignore** (Will explain this later) – select No.
 - 5) License (good to do if you creating a public repo) - select MIT License.
 - 6) Ignore copilot.
 - 7) Press “Create repository” *



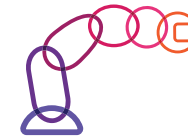
Using Git on your own - 2

- Now to open the new repo in a codespace.
 - 1) Find your new repo.
 - 2) Click on the green “Code” button, open the “Codespaces” tab and click on the “Create codespace on main” button.
 - 3) Once it has started, you should see an editor (a browser version of VSCode).
 - 4) Take a look at the **.git** directory. The **config** file contains information about the *origin* repo (normally the one on GitHub) and any branches.
 - 5) Basic information commands:
 - 1) **git status** – Tells you information about the state of the repo.
 - 2) **git log** – Tells you about each of the commits in the repo.
 - 6) Update the README file with a line or two of text: **README.md**



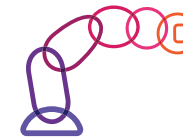
Using Git on your own - 3

- Continued:
 - 1) See what has changed: **git status**
 - 2) Tell Git about the new file by adding it to the repo: **git add README.md**
 - 3) See what has changed: **git status**. The new file is “staged” or ready to be committed to a new revision. You can add many files to the staged before committing.
 - 4) Let’s commit the change: **git commit -m “Updated README”**
 - 5) See what has changed: **git status**
 - 6) Check the log to see the new commit: **git log**
 - 7) This is the local Git work flow when developing code: Do some work, **git status**, **git add** file if new, **git commit -am “my commit message”**, and repeat.



Using Git on your own - 3

- So far, we have made a change in our codespace (a local change) but the GitHub repo has not been updated.
 - 1) Let's add a new file, **design.md**, and add a couple of lines of text to it.
 - 2) Commit it.
 - 3) Now we want to update the GitHub repo with our two changes so we don't lose them.
 - 4) To do this, we need to "push" our changes to the server using **git push**. The very handy defaults save us having to type the full command **git push origin master**.
 - 5) Check GitHub to see if your changes have appeared.
 - 6) Congratulations. Your code is now backed up and can be shared with others.
- Every we time we do a **git commit**, we are creating a new revision. Lets look at revisions in more detail.

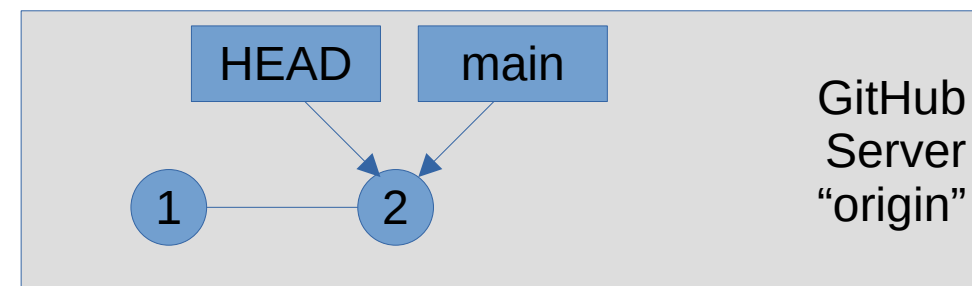
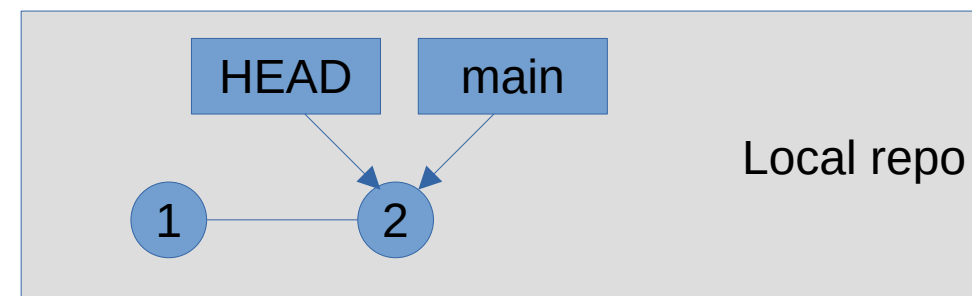


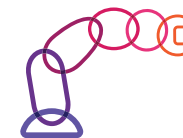
Revisions

- When we looked at the Git log, there is a long string of hexadecimal digits for each **commit**. This “commit hash” is a 40 character SHA-1 checksum of the snapshot of the directory tree, all files in it, the **commit** message and some other information. The hashes allows users to go back to old revisions or to compare revisions to see what has changed.
- You will also notice that the commit information has the following: “(**HEAD -> master, origin/master, origin/HEAD**) ”. Each of these is essentially a name that points to the commit.
- **HEAD** always points at the revision that is currently checked out. **main** is the branch name on the local repo and points to a specific revision. Generally, the branch name points to the newest revision on the branch.
- The GitHub server (a **remote** repo) has its own copy of the repo that has matching names. The local repo also knows about the names so they are prefixed with the word “**origin**” to avoid confusion.

```
commit ce59e0503f29708901ad9c49b7422d8fb0212a46
(HEAD -> main, origin/main, origin/HEAD)
Author: Andy Blight
<57393437+AndyBlightLeeds@users.noreply.github.com>
Date: Thu Apr 23 11:09:34 2026 +0000

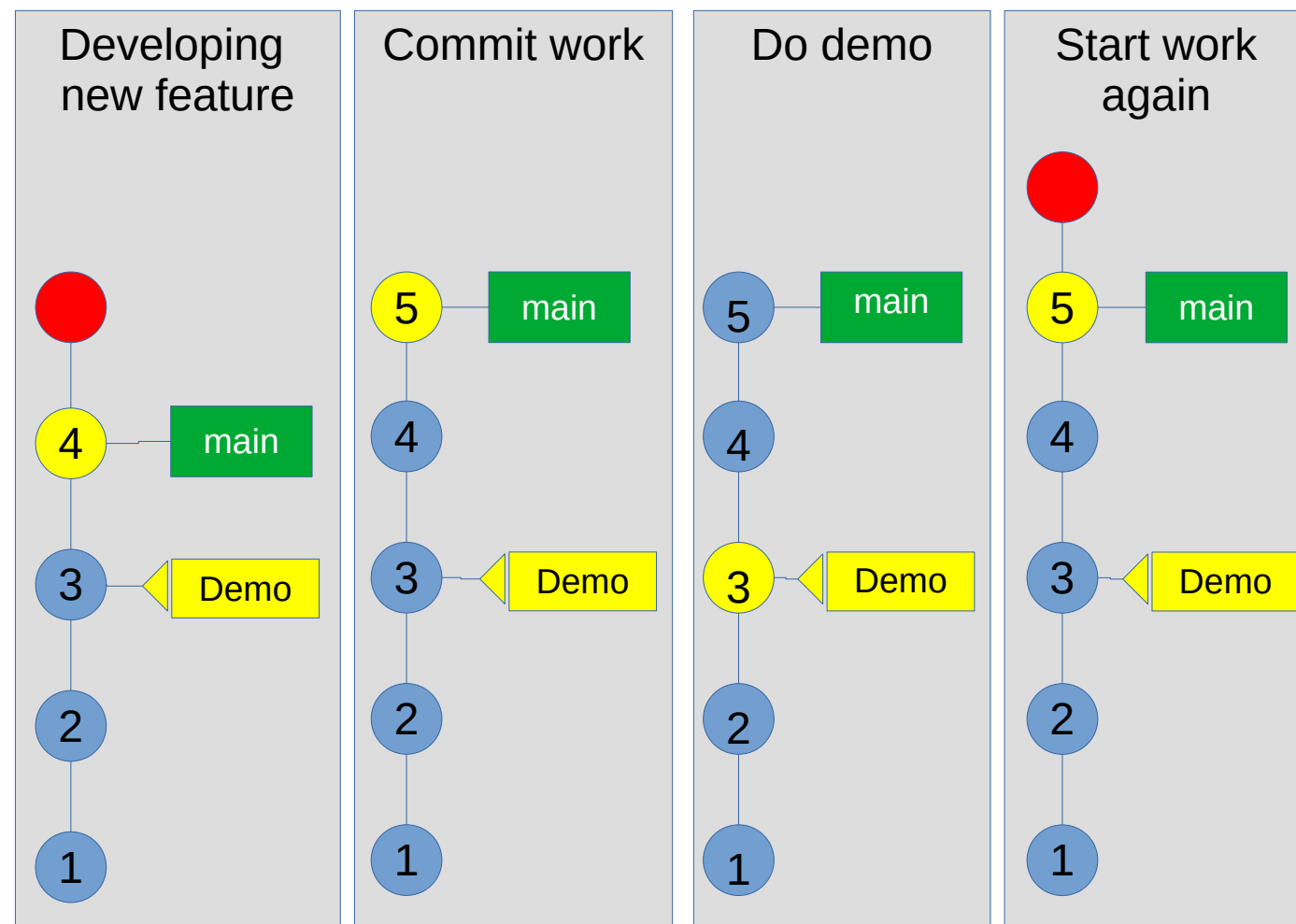
    Added diff dir
```

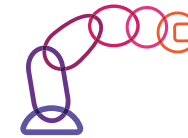




Revisions - 2

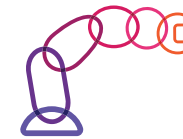
- One of the cool things about using Git is that we can go back in time (sort of!)
- For instance, you are working on adding a new feature, when your boss comes along and wants to you to show someone the demo you showed him last week. Fortunately, you added a custom label, a **tag**, to the version you showed your boss.
- You **commit** your current work.
- You **checkout** the **tag** and then do the demo.
- Afterwards, you **checkout** the branch name that you were working on and carry on with your work.





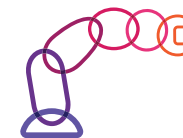
Revisions - Exercise

- Lets do what we have just talked about. Using the same codespace as before:
 - 1) Add a **tag** to the latest revision. `'git tag demo-1'`. Check the Git log to make sure it worked.
 - 2) Modify the **design.md** file, save and commit a new revision. `'git commit -am "My message"'`.
 - 3) Make some more changes to **design.md**.
 - 4) Boss comes along and asks you for a demo. What do you do?
 - 5) Save and commit your work. `'git commit -am "My message"'`.
 - 6) Checkout the tagged revision. `"git checkout demo-1"`
 - 7) Do the demo.
 - 8) Checkout the tip of the main branch. `"git checkout main"`
 - 9) Start work again.



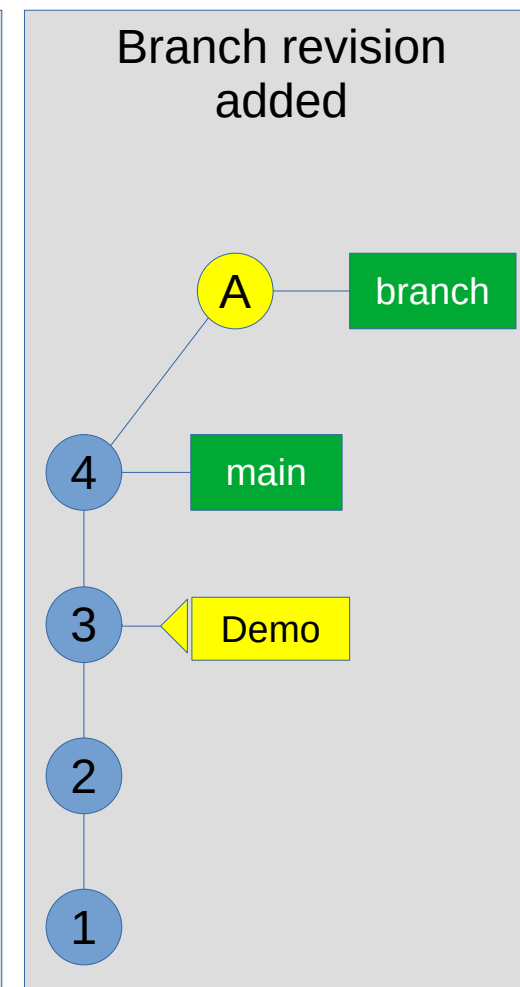
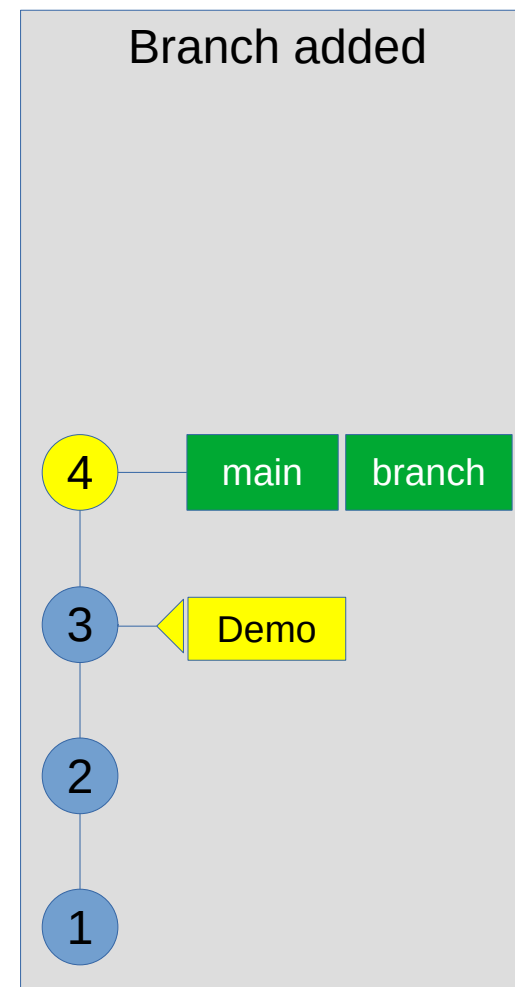
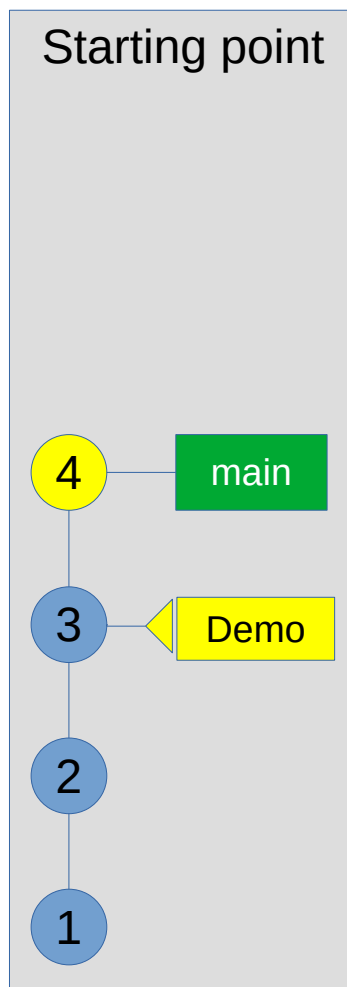
Working in small teams

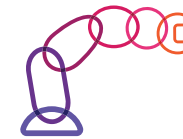
- There are several ways to collaborate using Git.
- The simplest is to let everyone in the team push directly to the `main` branch. This can be used for very small teams, say two or three people maximum but needs clear communication to avoid making mistakes. This is OK if only one person is working on the repo at a time but as soon as two people start work at the same time, things get difficult, so this is not recommended.
- A better way is for all changes have to be done on different branches. This way, several people can work on their own version of the code for as long as they like, and only when they are ready, merge their changes back to the `main` branch.
- We'll explore these methods in the next practical, but first we need to understand what branches are and how they are used.



Branches – What are they?

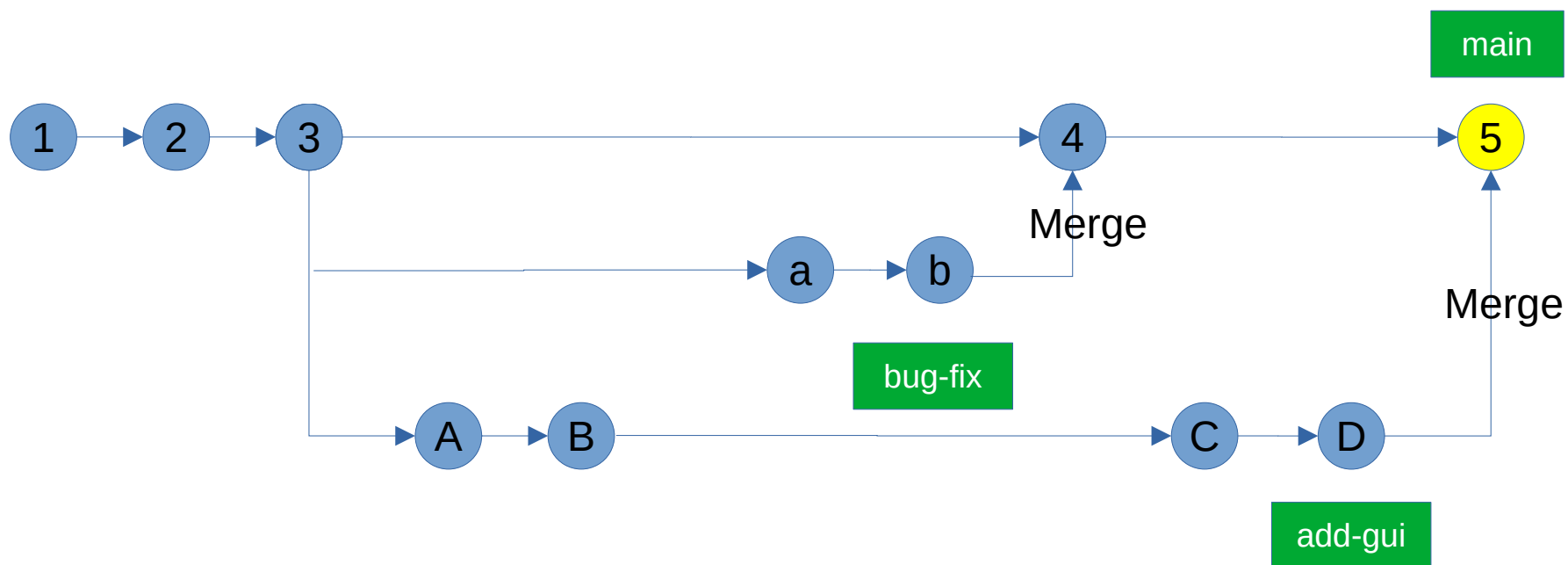
- So, what is a branch? It is essentially a label that points at a commit in a similar way to the *tag* that we used in the previous section. The *main* branch is a branch.
- When we create a new branch, all that happens is that a new label is added to the current revision.
- Once we switch to the new branch and *commit* a new revision, then the branch starts to live its own life.

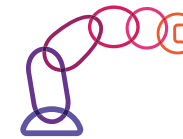




Branches - Example

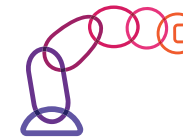
- This is an example of how one person might use two branches to work on adding a new feature and fix a bug “at the same time”. Once the changes are ready, the changes are *merged* back to the main branch.





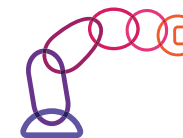
Branches - Exercise

- Time to replicate the example we just saw. Open up your Codespace again and:
 - Create a branch and switch to it: **git switch -c add-gui**
 - Use **git log** to see the new branch.
 - Add a new file, add some content, save and **commit**. Make some more changes to that file, save and **commit**.
 - Use **git log** to see the new commits and where the branch labels are.
 - We now need to fix a bug, so *switch* back to the *main* branch: **git switch main**
 - *Switch* to the new *bug-fix* branch: **git switch -c bug-fix**
 - Make some small changes, **commit**, make some more changes and **commit**.
 - Use **git log** to see the new commits and where the branch labels are.
 - Now we need to *merge* the changes back to the *main* branch (next slide).



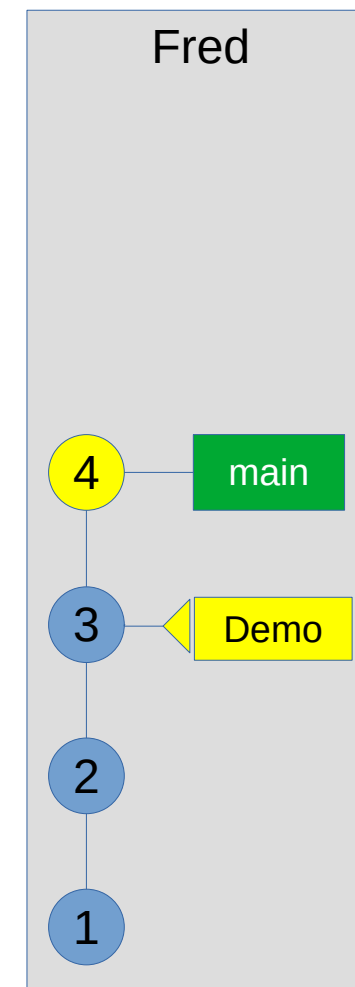
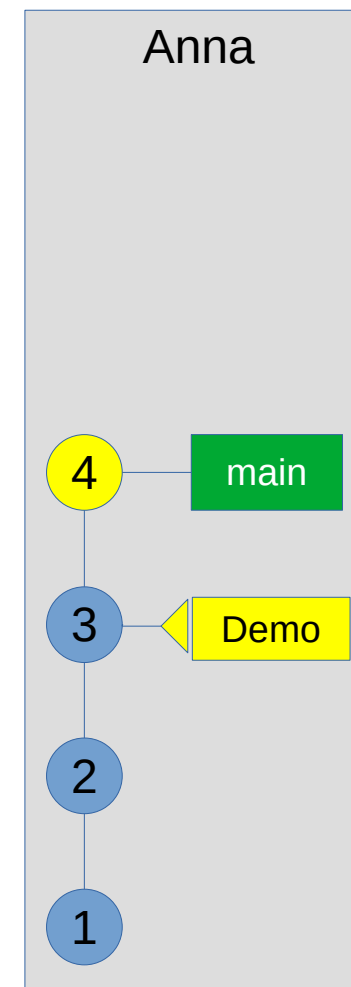
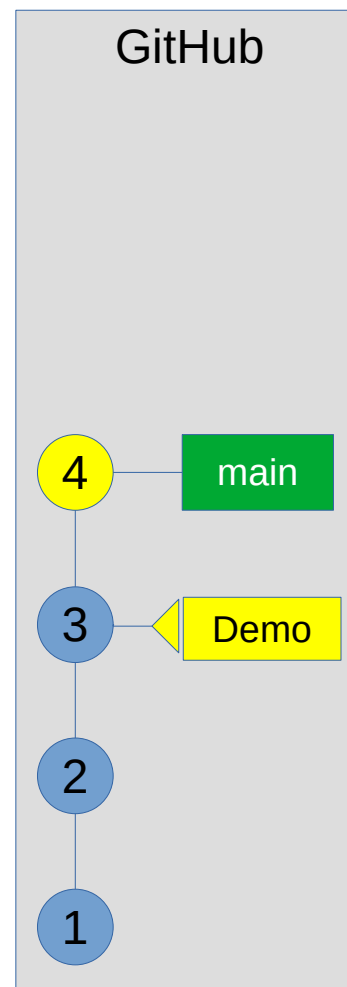
Branches – Exercise 2

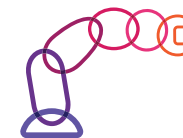
- **git switch main**
- Use **git log** to see how things have changed.
- **git merge bug-fix**
- The bug has been fixed so we can get on with the new feature, so we *switch* back to the *add-gui* branch.
- Use **git log** to see how things have changed.
- Make some small changes, *commit*, make some more changes and *commit*.
- Use **git log** to see how things have changed.
- Now we need to *merge* the changes back to the *main* branch.
- **git switch main**
- **git merge add-gui**
- Use **git log** to see how things have changed.



Working in small teams 2

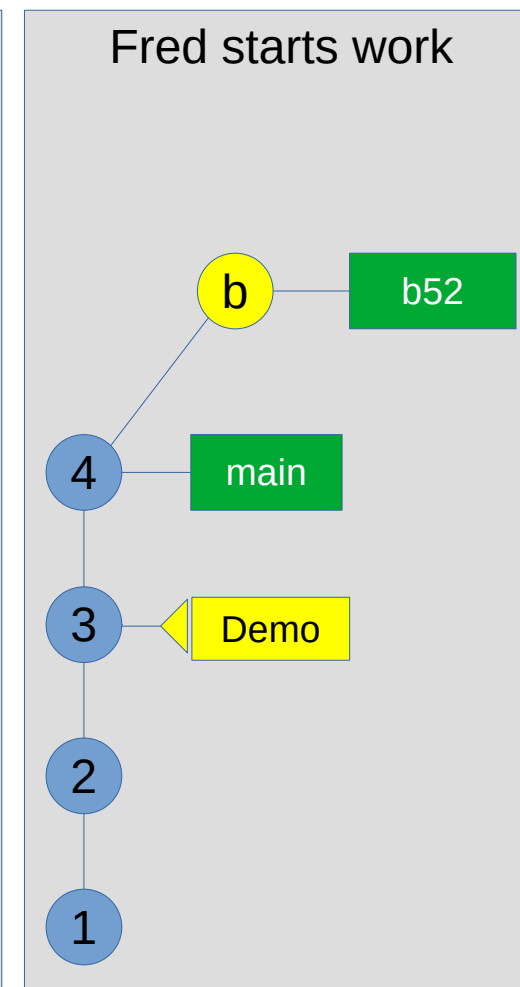
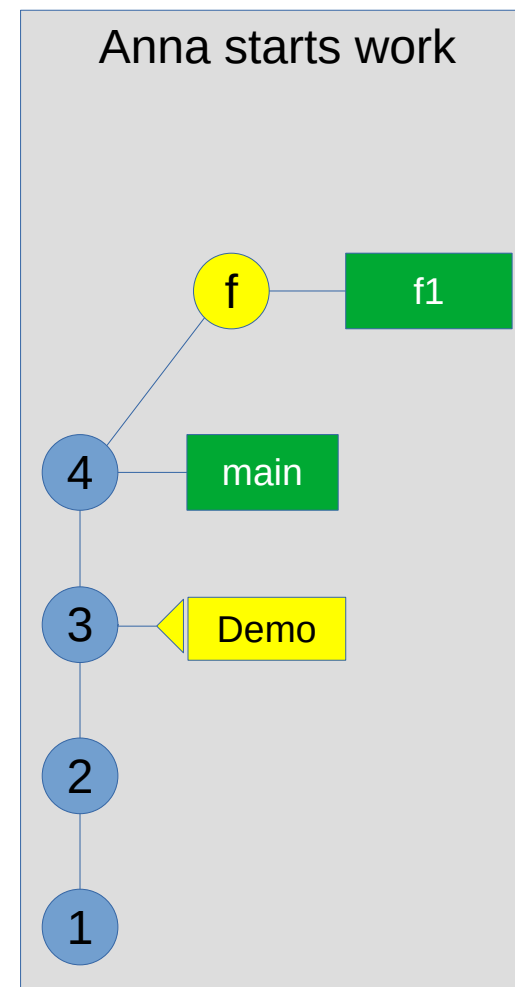
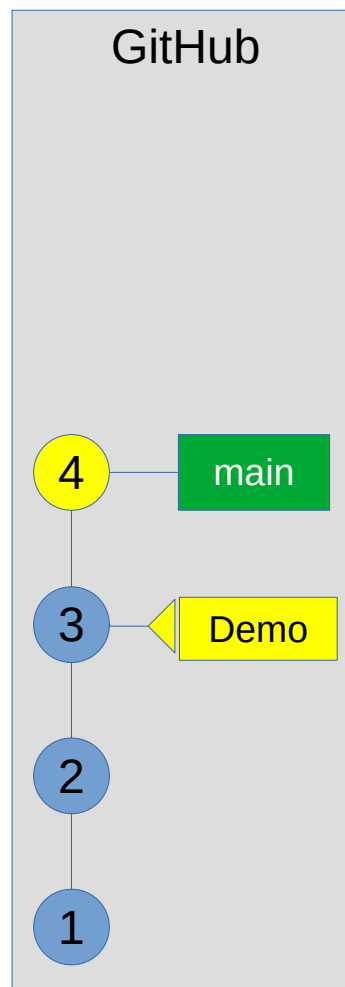
- Now that we know what branches are and how to use them, working in a small team using branches is pretty much the same as working on your own, with a few small differences.
- The first difference is that several repos are involved: the GitHub repo and one repo of each developer on their local PCs or Codespace.
- This is what each repo might look like after Anna and Fred have cloned the GitHub repo.

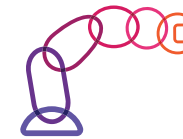




Working in small teams 3

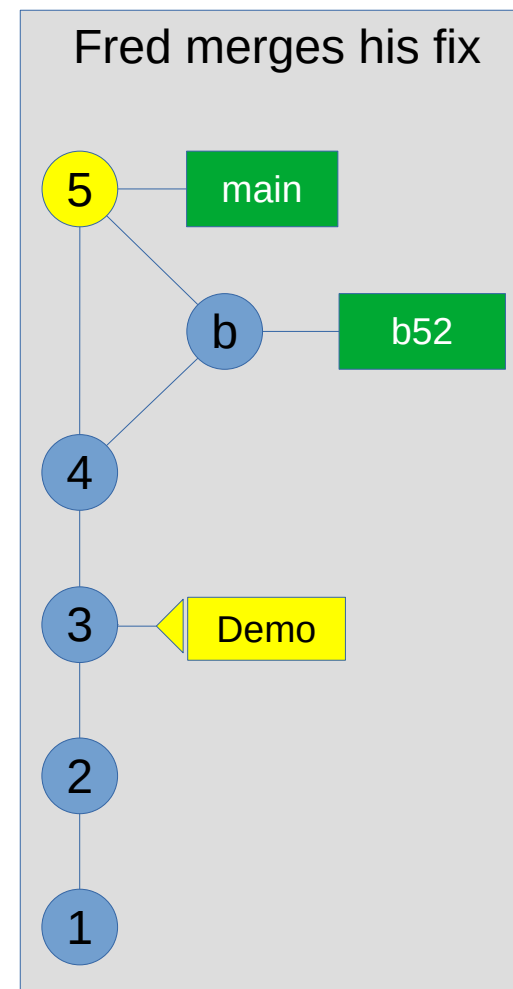
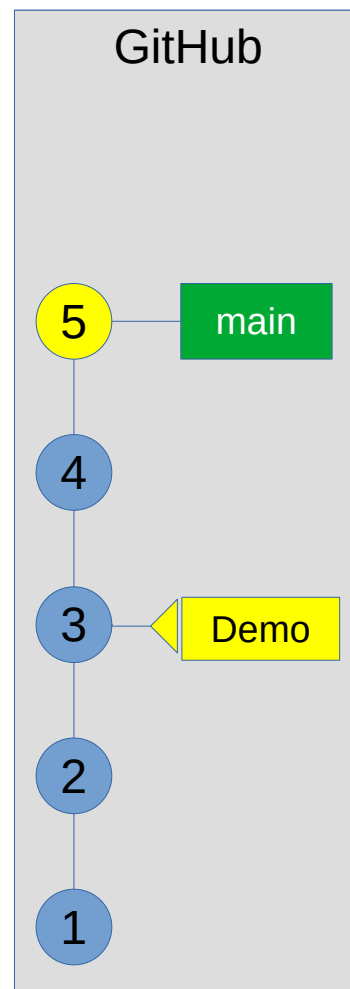
- Anna starts work a new feature, f1, so she creates a new branch with that name.
- Fred then starts work on a bug fix, b52, so he creates a new branch with that name.
- Note: branch names should be more descriptive than f1 and b52. I've kept them short as the fit on the diagram better.
- A new feature should use something like "feature/add-select-file-page". This makes it much easier for reviewers (and the developer) to know what is going on.

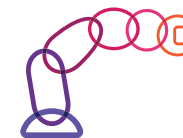




Working in small teams 4

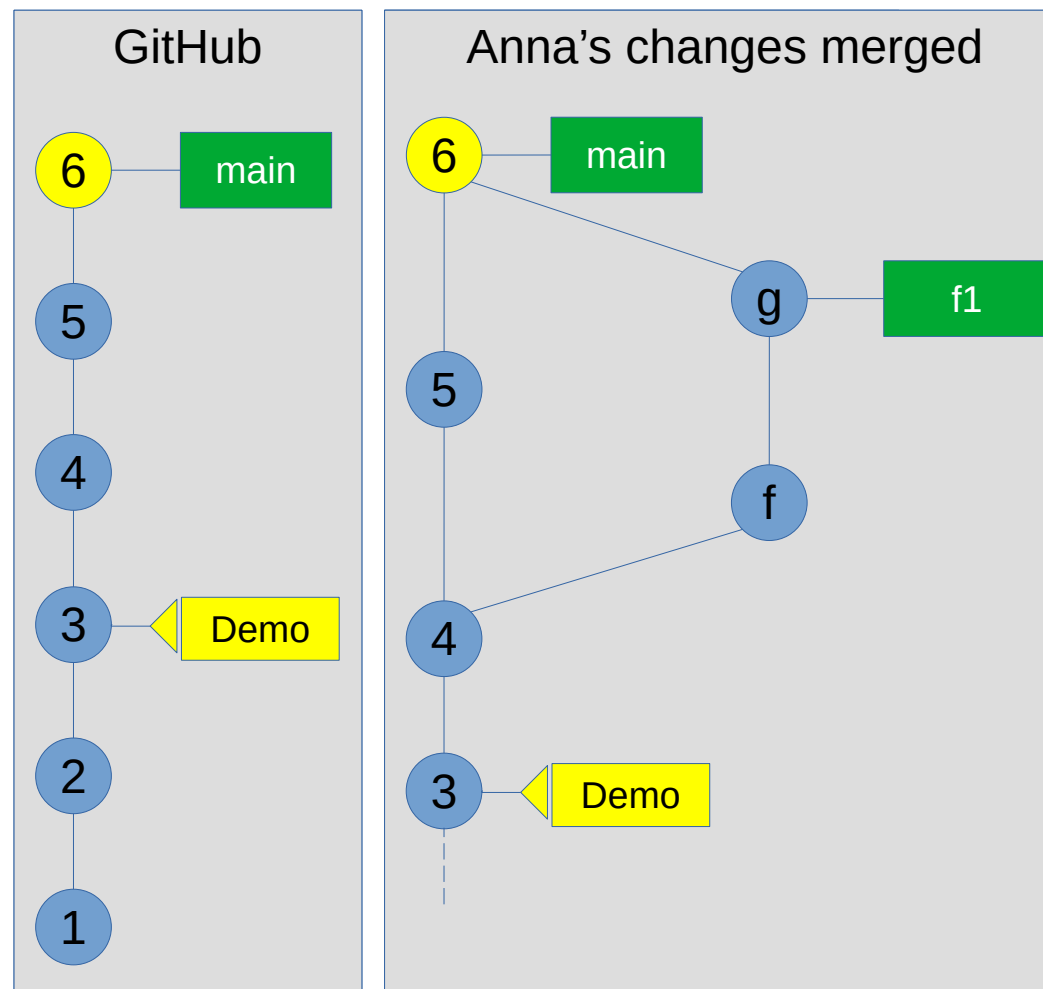
- Fred finishes his bug fix and merges the change to his local main branch.
- Then he pushes the new revision to the server.

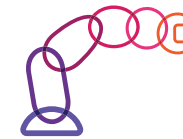




Working in small teams 5

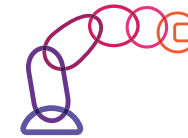
- Anna finishes the next day. She checks the GitHub repo and sees that a new change has been added to the main branch.
- Anna switches to the main branch and pulls the latest revision from the GitHub repo.
- Anna then merges her changes into the latest revision of main in her repo.
- Anna then pushes her changes to the GitHub server.





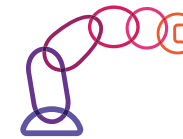
Working in small teams 6

- What can go wrong with this process? Any ideas?
- Anna forgets to pull first, merges her work and then pushes her changes to the server. This would overwrite the bug fix that Fred put in, so not good.
- In practice, this doesn't happen any more as Git has extra checks in place to prevent this happening. If Anna did this, she would receive a warning message when she tried to push and the change would stay local. Then she would have to sort out the problem locally, and push again.
- Before we get on with the next exercise, we need to get your PC set up to use Git and GitHub.



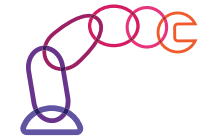
PC setup – GitHub Desktop

- Lets configure our PCs for using Git and GitHub. There are two main tools that make Git easier to use on Windows PCs: GitHub Desktop and VS Code. VS Code is more fully featured and is what I'll be using, but GitHub Desktop is easier to install.
- GitHub Desktop
 - This is the quickest and easiest to install. Useful links:
 - <https://docs.github.com/en/desktop/overview/getting-started-with-github-desktop>
 - <https://desktop.github.com/download/>
 - If you haven't connected your GitHub Desktop to you GitHub account, follow these instructions:
 - <https://docs.github.com/en/desktop/installing-and-authenticating-to-github-desktop/authenticating-to-github-in-github-desktop>
 - You are ready to go!



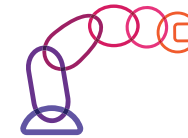
PC setup – VS Code

- Visual Studio Code (VS Code)
 - This is an integrated development environment (IDE) that has a really good source control extension that works really well with Git. Full installation and basic use instructions can be found here: <https://code.visualstudio.com/docs/sourcecontrol/overview>
 - My rough summary.
 - Install VS Code.
 - Install latest Git Bash to make the version control extension work correctly. There are lots of options. The defaults work pretty well, but choose VS code as the editor.
 - Configure your Git installation by opening the terminal in VS code (or a PowerShell) and enter the commands. This info is needed for each commit.
 - **git config --global user.name "John Doe"**
 - **git config --global user.email johndoe@example.com**
 - Connect VS Code to GitHub: <https://code.visualstudio.com/docs/sourcecontrol/github>



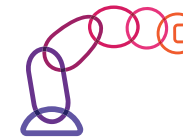
PC Setup Test

- Now that we have setup our PCs, let's see how easy it is to create a local repository. Just follow along with my demo for the method you want to use.
- I like to keep all my Git repos in a folder so they are easy to find, so I use this path for store my Git files: "C:\Users\<USER NAME>\git".
- Now we have to initialise a new Git repo.
 - In GitHub Desktop: File → New Repository. Fill in name, set path and press "Create repository". Show new files in History tab. Open the "README.md" in the editor, make a change, save the file. In GitHub Desktop, look at the changes and commit them.
 - In VS Code: File → Close folder, File → Open Folder, navigate to "C:\Users\<USER NAME>\git", create a new folder called "my-repo", select the new folder and press "Select Folder". Add a file called "README.md". Click on the source control icon, then "Initialize Repository". Commit the new files. Modify the "README.md" file, save it, check it and commit. Look at the changes in the "Graph" section.



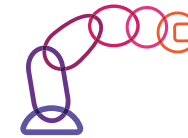
PC Setup Test - 2

- Continued...
 - If you are feeling brave, you can also do all of this from PowerShell like this:
 - `cd C:\Users\<USER NAME>\git`
 - `ls`
 - `mkdir my-cli-repo`
 - `cd .\my-cli-repo\`
 - `code README.md` # Add some text in the file and save it.
 - `git init .`
 - `git status`
 - `git add .`
 - `git status`
 - `git log`
- Now that we have created our local repo, lets take a look at it using "File Explorer". Navigate to "C:\Users\<USER NAME>\git" then into your new repo. Look at the **README.md** file and the **.git** folder.
- End of session 1



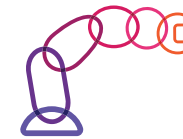
Exercise – Working in small teams

- Clone this repo: **git@github.com:AndyBlightLeeds/git-github-practicals.git** for the exercises.
- Before you can push and changes to this repo, you need to be added as a collaborator. Put your GitHub user names in the chat, and I'll add you. You'll get an invitation email that you have to reply to.
- Open the repo in VS Code, open the file **working-in-small-teams-windows/README.md** and follow the instructions.
- There are two points where I ask you to wait. I'll do a quick demo and then let you have a go. I'm hoping for a couple of problems with the merges so just let me know and we can talk them through.



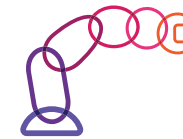
Contributing to open source projects

- So how do you contribute to an open source project using GitHub?
- Find a repo that you want to contribute to. This is often a repo that you are using but want to make a change or fix a bug.
- The process is:
 - Fork the open source repo – for reference: <https://docs.github.com/en/pull-requests/collaborating-with-pull-requests/working-with-forks/fork-a-repo>
 - Clone the forked repo.
 - Create a branch for your changes.
 - Do the work on the new branch.
 - Test and document.
 - Push the branch to your repo
 - Continued...



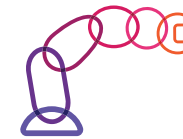
Contributing to open source projects 2

- The process continued:
 - Go to your forked repo on GitHub and submit a pull request (PR). This PR will appear on the list of PRs on the maintainer's repo.
 - The maintainer of the open source repo will review your change, ask you to fix some things or if there is nothing wrong, they will merge it to the default branch.
- One of the key benefits of this approach is that you don't have to be set up as a collaborator, so it is easy for anyone to submit PRs. The reason is that you are only working with your own fork of the repo, and only the PRs are sent to the maintainer's repo. The maintainer then gets to decide which PRs get merged, so there can be quite a bit of review work involved.
- Continued...



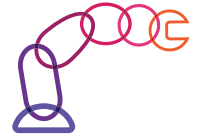
Other times to use forks

- I forked several repos when I was working on the Pipebots project. Why?
- The main reason was to prevent upstream developers changing the code we were using. If you have a robot that works, you don't want other people breaking your robot. The `main` branch could be updated but this was only done when I decided that the project was in a state where we could fix any bugs introduced.
- The second reason was to make small changes to the configuration data for your robot. To do this, a branch was created, the changes made and committed. Then whenever anyone setup a new robot, they would have the correct configuration settings.
- Finally, there were a couple of bug fixes that were needed when we built some code on a Raspberry Pi. Again, these were kept on a branch.
- To manage all the repos on a robot, I used Bash scripts and a tool called `vcstool` to clone the correct repos and branches to be used for that robot.

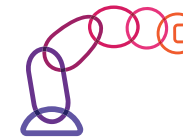


Exercise – Contributing to my repo

- In this exercise, I have created a repo that is setup like an Open Source project repo would be setup.
- I have setup a repo that operates like an open source repo. Link for the repo:
<https://github.com/AndyBlightLeeds/git-github-open-source-repo>
- The README has all the instructions. Once you have pushed your changes and I'll show you how to create a PR and how the maintainer does reviews and merges your changes.

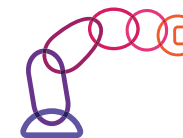


- GitHub Enterprise is free for academic use. It took about 6 months to get it set up for the University of Leeds as our legal department got involved.
- Benefits:
 - Setup organisations, e.g. one per school, institute or even multi-uni projects. (Show them the organisations I have setup). I am the admin for all of these organisations.
 - Have a group of university super admins that over see all repos, so if access is lost, it can be accessed again.
 - Data security: Backups that you don't have to think about.
 - 25,000 licenses. We've used just over a 2000 in 5 years.
 - Can transfer repos from one organisation to another.
 - Classroom options available as well.
- Let's take a look at the setup I look after at Leeds.



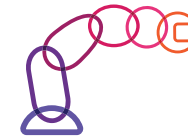
Final tricks and tips

- There is one file that is useful to know about called **.gitignore** It tells Git to ignore files that match the patterns that are in the **.gitignore** file. For example:
 - ***.tmp** will ignore all files ending in **.tmp**
 - ****/.vscode** will ignore all directories anywhere in the tree that have the name **.vscode**
 - This is really useful when you are building C or C++ projects as the compiler generates many intermediate files that you do not want to keep.
 - I'll give you a quick demo...



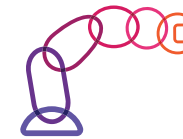
Anything else?

- Questions, thoughts, any feedback.
- Fill out the survey: https://www.smartsurvey.co.uk/s/UK_RAS_STEPS_activities_feedback/



References

- There is lots of information on Git and GitHub on the Internet. Here are some of the references I used when creating this workshop.
 - <https://git-scm.com/> This is my go to reference for using Git. It has lots of detail, so might be confusing for beginners.
 - <https://git-scm.com/book/en/v2/Getting-Started-A-Short-History-of-Git>
 - <https://git-scm.com/book/en/v2/Git-Branching-Basic-Branching-and-Merging>
 - <https://arctraining.github.io/git/> I used this as a starting point for this course. Might be useful as a reference.
 - Continued...



References

- GitHub docs
 - [Everything to do with GitHub is documented here](#)
 - [GitHub work flow \(PRs and reviews\)](#)
 - [Fork a repo](#)
 - [Create a personal access token](#)
 - [Create an SSH key](#)